

the Jesuit and Aramis, having the Dominican in front of him, and smiling particularly at the Dominican, whose jolly, fat face pleased him much. The repast was long and sumptuous; excellent Spanish wine, fine Morbihan oysters, exquisite fish from the mouth of the Loire, enormous prawns from Paimboeuf, and delicious game from the moors, constituted the principal part of it. D'Arragnan ate much, and drank but little. Aramis drank nothing, unless it was water. After the repast,—

'You offered me an arquebus,' said D'Arragnan.

'I did.'

'Lend it me, then.'

'Are you going shooting?'

'Whilst waiting for Porthos, it is the best thing I can do, I think.'

'Take which you like from the trophy.'

'Will you not come with me?'

'I would with great pleasure; but, alas! my friend, sporting is forbidden to bishops.'

'Ah!' said D'Arragnan, 'I did not know that.'

'Besides,' continued Aramis, 'I shall be busy till mid-day.'

'I shall go alone, then?' said D'Arragnan.

'I am sorry to say you must; but come back to dinner.'

'*Partieu!* the eating at your house is too good to make me think of not coming back.' And thereupon D'Arragnan quitted his host, bowed to the guests, and took his arquebus; but instead of shooting, went straight to the little port of Vannes. He looked in vain to observe if anybody saw him; he could discern neither thing nor person. He engaged a little fishing boat for twenty-five livres, and set off at half-past eleven, convinced that he had not been followed; and that was true, he had not been followed; only a Jesuit brother, placed in the top of the steeple of his church, had not, since the morning, by the help of an excellent glass, lost sight of one of his steps. At three quarters past eleven, Aramis was informed that D'Arragnan was sailing towards Belle-Isle. The voyage was rapid; a good north north-east wind drove him towards the isle. As he approached, his eyes were constantly fixed upon the coast. He looked to see if, upon the shore or upon the fortifications the brilliant dress and vast stature of Porthos should stand out against a slightly clouded sky; but his search was in vain. He landed without having seen anything; and learnt from the first

soldier interrogated by him, that M. du Vallon had not yet returned from Vannes. Then, without losing an instant, D'Arragnan ordered his little bark to put its head towards Sarzeau. We know that the wind changes with the different hours of the day. The breeze had veered from the north north-east to the south-east; the wind, then, was almost as good for the return to Sarzeau, as it had been for the voyage to Belle-Isle. In three hours D'Arragnan had touched the continent; two hours more sufficed for his ride to Vannes. In spite of the rapidity of his passage, what D'Arragnan endured of impatience and anger during that short passage, the deck alone of the vessel, upon which he stamped backwards and forwards for three hours, could testify. He made but one bound from the quay whereon he landed to the episcopal palace. He thought to terrify Aramis by the promptitude of his return; he wished to reproach him with his duplicity, and yet with reserve; but with sufficient spirit, nevertheless, to make him feel all the consequences of it, and force from him a part of his secret. He hoped, in short—thanks to that heat of expression which is to secrets what the charge with the bayonet is to redoubts—to bring the mysterious Aramis to some manifestation or other. But he found, in the vestibule of the palace, the valet de chambre, who closed his passage, while smiling upon him with a stupid air.

'Monseigneur?' cried D'Arragnan, endeavouring to put him aside with his hand. Moved for an instant the valet resumed his station.

'Monseigneur?' said he.

'Yes, to be sure; do you not know me, imbecile?'

'Yes; you are the Chevalier d'Arragnan.'

'Then let me pass.'

'It is of no use.'

'Why of no use?'

'Because His Greatness is not at home.'

'What! His Greatness is not at home? where is he, then?'

'Gone.'

'Gone?'

'Yes.'

'Whither?'

'I don't know; but perhaps he tells monsieur le chevalier.'

'And how? where? in what fashion?'

'In this letter, which he gave me for monsieur le chevalier.' And the valet de chambre drew a letter from his pocket.

'Give it me, then, you rascal,' said D'Artagnan, snatching it from his hand. 'Oh, yes,' continued he, at the first line, 'yes, I understand,' and he read:—

Dear Friend,

An affair of the most urgent nature calls me to a distant parish of my diocese. I hoped to see you again before I set out, but I lose that hope in thinking that you are going, no doubt, to remain two or three days at Belle-Isle, with our dear Porthos. Amuse yourself as well as you can; but do not attempt to hold out against him at table. This is a counsel I might have given even to Athos, in his most brilliant and best days. Adieu, dear friend; believe that I regret greatly not having better, and for a longer time, profited by your excellent company.

'*Mordiana!*' cried D'Artagnan. 'I am tricked. Ah! blockhead, brute, triple fool that I am! But those laugh best who laugh last. Oh, duped, duped like a monkey, cheated with an empty nutshell!' And with a hearty blow bestowed upon the nose of the smirking valet de chambre, he made all haste out of the episcopal palace. Furet, however good a trotter, was not equal to present circumstances. D'Artagnan therefore took the post, and chose a horse which he soon caused to demonstrate, with good spurs and a light hand, that deer are not the swiftest animals in nature.

'Well?' asked the bishop.

'Monseigneur, he has followed the course of the canal, and is going towards the sea,' said the servant.

'Very well!' said Aramis.

In fact, D'Artagnan, dismissing all suspicion, hastened towards the ocean, constantly hoping to see in the Landes, or on the beach, the colossal profile of Porthos. He persisted in fancying he could trace a horse's steps in every puddle. Sometimes he imagined he heard the report of a gun. This illusion lasted three hours; during two of which he went forward in search of his friend—in the last he returned to the house.

'We must have crossed,' said he, 'and I shall find them waiting for me at table.'

D'Artagnan was mistaken. He no more found Porthos at the palace than he had found him on the sea-shore. Aramis was waiting for him at the top of the stairs, looking very much concerned.

'Did my people not find you, my dear D'Artagnan?' cried he, as soon as he caught sight of the musketeer.

'No; did you send any one after me?'

'I am deeply concerned, my friend, deeply, to have induced you to make such a useless search; but, about seven o'clock, the almoner of Saint-Paten came here. He had met Du Vallon, who was going away, and who, being unwilling to disturb anybody at the palace, had charged him to tell me that, fearing M. Getard would play him some ill turn in his absence, he was going to take advantage of the morning tide to make a tour of Belle-Isle.'

'But tell me, Goliath has not crossed the four leagues of sea, I should think.'

'There are full six,' said Aramis.

'That makes it less probable still.'

'Therefore, my friend,' said Aramis, with one of his blandest smiles, 'Goliath is in the stable, well pleased. I will answer for it, that Porthos is no longer on his back.' In fact, the horse had been brought back from the relay by the direction of the prelate, from whom no detail escaped. D'Artagnan appeared as well satisfied with as possible with the explanation. He entered upon a part of dissimulation which agreed perfectly with the suspicions that arose more strongly in his mind. He breakfasted between

‘What to do?’

‘To see if Porthos had departed on horseback.’

‘And?’ interrogated the bishop.

‘Well, there is a horse missing, stall No. 3, Goliath.’

All this dialogue, it may be easily understood, was not exempt from a certain affectation on the part of the musketeer, and a perfect complaisance on the part of Aramis.

‘Oh! I guess how it is,’ said Aramis, after having considered for a moment, ‘Porthos is gone out to give us a surprise.’

‘A surprise?’

‘Yes; the canal which goes from Yannes to the sea abounds in teal and snipes; that is Porthos’s favourite sport, and he will bring us back a dozen for breakfast.’

‘Do you think so?’ said D’Artagnan.

‘I am sure of it. Where else can he be? I would lay a wager he took a gun with him.’

‘Well, that is possible,’ said D’Artagnan.

‘Do one thing, my friend. Get on horseback, and join him.’

‘You are right,’ said D’Artagnan, ‘I will.’

‘Shall I go with you?’

‘No, thank you; Porthos is a rather remarkable man: I will inquire as I go along.’

‘Will you take an arquebus?’

‘Thank you.’

‘Order what horse you like to be saddled.’

‘The one I rode yesterday, on coming from Belle-Isle.’

‘So be it: use the horse as your own.’

Aramis rang, and gave orders to have the horse M. d’Artagnan had chosen saddled.

D’Artagnan followed the servant charged with the execution of this order. When arrived at the door, the servant drew on one side to allow M. d’Artagnan to pass; and at that moment he caught the eye of his master. A knitting of the brow gave the intelligent spy to understand that all should be given to D’Artagnan he wished. D’Artagnan got into the saddle, and Aramis heard the steps of his horse on the pavement. An instant after, the servant returned.

Chapter LXXIV D’Artagnan Makes All Speed, Porthos Snores, and Aramis Counsels



FROM thirty to thirty-five hours after the events we have just related, as M. Fouquet, according to his custom, having interdicted his door, was working in the cabinet of his house at Saint-Mande, with which we are already acquainted, a carriage, drawn by four horses steaming with sweat, entered the court at full gallop. This carriage was, probably, expected; for three or four lackeys hastened to the door, which they opened. Whilst M. Fouquet rose from his bureau and ran to the window, a man got painfully out of the carriage, descending with difficulty the three steps of the door, leaning upon the shoulders of the lackeys. He had scarcely uttered his name, when the valet upon whom he was not leaning, sprang up to the perron, and disappeared in the vestibule. This man went to inform his master; but he had no occasion to knock at the door: Fouquet was standing on the threshold.

‘Monseigneur, the Bishop of Yannes,’ said he.

‘Very well!’ replied his master.

Then, leaning over the banister of the staircase, of which Aramis was beginning to ascend the first steps,—

‘Ah, dear friend!’ said he, ‘you, so soon!’

‘Yes, I, myself, monsieur! but bruised, battered, as you see.’

‘Oh! my poor friend,’ said Fouquet, presenting him his arm, on which Aramis leant, whilst the servants drew back respectfully.

'Bah!' replied Aramis, 'it is nothing, since I am here; the principal thing was that I should get here, and here I am.'

'Speak quickly,' said Fouquet, closing the door of the cabinet behind Aramis and himself.

'Are we alone?'

'Yes, perfectly.'

'No one observes us?—no one can hear us?'

'Be satisfied; nobody.'

'Is M. du Vallon arrived?'

'Yes.'

'And you have received my letter?'

'Yes. The affair is serious, apparently, since it necessitates your attendance in Paris, at a moment when your presence was so urgent elsewhere.'

'You are right, it could not be more serious.'

'Thank you! thank you! What is it about? But, for God's sake! before anything else, take time to breathe, dear friend. You are so pale, you frighten me.'

'I am really in great pain. But, for Heaven's sake, think nothing about me. Did M. du Vallon tell you nothing, when he delivered the letter to you?'

'No; I heard a great noise; I went to the window; I saw at the foot of the perron a sort of horseman of marble; I went down, he held the letter out to me, and his horse fell down dead.'

'But he?'

'He fell with the horse; he was lifted, and carried to an apartment. Having read the letter, I went up to him, in hopes of obtaining more ample information; but he was asleep, and, after such a fashion, that it was impossible to wake him. I took pity on him; I gave orders that his boots should be cut from off his legs, and that he should be left quite undisturbed.'

'So far well; now, this is the question in hand, monseigneur. You have seen M. d'Arragnan in Paris, have you not?'

'Certes, and think him a man of intelligence, and even a man of heart; although he did bring about the death of our dear friends, Lyodot and D'Eymerys.'

'Hush!' said Aramis, 'we are already no longer alone, I hear strangers coming up.'

'Well, dismiss them.'

'Impossible; I made an appointment with them yesterday; it is the principal of the college of the Jesuits, and the superior of the Dominicans.'

'Your staff? Well, so be it.'

'What are you going to do?'

'I will go and wake Porthos, and remain in his company till you have finished the conference.'

Aramis did not stir, his brow remained unbent, he betrayed himself by no gesture or word; 'Go,' said he, as D'Arragnan advanced to the door. 'À propos, do you know where Porthos sleeps?'

'No, but I will inquire.'

'Take the corridor, and open the second door on the left.'

'Thank you! au revoir.' And D'Arragnan departed in the direction pointed out by Aramis.

Ten minutes had not passed away when he came back. He found Aramis seated between the superior of the Dominicans and the principal of the college of the Jesuits, exactly in the same situation as he had found him formerly in the auberge at Crèvecoeur. This company did not at all terrify the musketeer.

'What is it?' said Aramis, quietly. 'You have apparently something to say to me, my friend.'

'It is,' replied D'Arragnan, fixing his eyes upon Aramis, 'it is that Porthos is not in his apartment.'

'Indeed,' said Aramis calmly, 'are you sure?'

'*Parbleu!* I came from his chamber.'

'Where can he be, then?'

'That is what I am asking you.'

'And have you not inquired?'

'Yes, I have.'

'And what answer did you get?'

'That Porthos, often walking out in a morning, without saying anything, had probably gone out.'

'What did you do, then?'

'I went to the stables,' replied D'Arragnan, carelessly.

'And it is exactly on account of what you tell me, that I am so fond of being there now.'

'Then you confess, that it is not for the sake of sleeping, that you have put me off till eight o'clock.'

'I have been afraid you would laugh at me, if I told you the truth.'

'Tell me, notwithstanding.'

'Well, from six to eight, I am accustomed to perform my devotions.'

'Your devotions?'

'Yes.'

'I did not believe a bishop's exercises were so severe.'

'A bishop, my friend, must sacrifice more to appearance than a simple cleric.'

'*Mordieu!* Aramis, that is a word which reconciles me with your greatness. To appearances! That is a musketeer's word, in good truth! Vivent les apparences, Aramis!'

'Instead of felicitating me upon it, pardon me, D'Artagnan. It is a very mundane word which I had allowed to escape me.'

'Must I leave you, then?'

'I want time to collect my thoughts, my friend, and for my usual prayers.'

'Well, I leave you to them; but on account of that poor pagan, D'Artagnan, abridge them for once, I beg; I thirst for speech with you.'

'Well, D'Artagnan, I promise you that within an hour and a half—'

'An hour and a half of devotions! Ah! my friend, be as reasonable with me as you can. Let me have the best bargain possible.'

Aramis began to laugh.

'Still agreeable, still young, still gay,' said he. 'You have come into my diocese to set me quarrelling with grace.'

'Bah!'

'And you know well that I was never able to resist your seductions; you will cost me my salvation, D'Artagnan.'

D'Artagnan bit his lips.

'Well,' said he, 'I will take the sin on my own head, favour me with one simple Christian sign of the cross, favour me with one prayer, and we will part.'

'Alas! yes, I heard of that. At Tours I met the courier who was bringing the letter from Gourville, and the dispatches from Pelisson. Have you seriously reflected on that event, monsieur?'

'Yes.'

'And in it you perceived a direct attack upon your sovereignty?'

'And do you believe it to be so?'

'Oh, yes, I think so.'

'Well, I must confess, that sad idea occurred to me likewise.'

'Do not blind yourself, monsieur, in the name of Heaven! Listen attentively to me,—I return to D'Artagnan.'

'I am all attention.'

'Under what circumstances did you see him?'

'He came here for money.'

'With what kind of order?'

'With an order from the king.'

'Direct?'

'Signed by his majesty.'

'There, then! Well, D'Artagnan has been to Belle-Isle; he was disguised; he came in the character of some sort of an intendant, charged by his master to purchase salt-mines. Now, D'Artagnan has no other master but the king: he came, then, sent by the king. He saw Porthos.'

'Who is Porthos?'

'I beg your pardon, I made a mistake. He saw M. du Vallon at Belle-Isle; and he knows, as well as you and I do, that Belle-Isle is fortified.'

'And you think that the king sent him there?' said Fouquet, pensively. 'I certainly do.'

'And D'Artagnan, in the hands of the king, is a dangerous instrument?'

'The most dangerous imaginable.'

'Then I formed a correct opinion of him at the first glance.'

'How so?'

'I wished to attach him to myself.'

'If you judged him to be the bravest, the most acute, and the most adroit man in France, you judged correctly.'

'He must be had then, at any price.'

'D'Artagnan?'

'Is that not your opinion?'

'It may be my opinion, but you will never get him.'

'Why?'

'Because we have allowed the time to go by. He was dissatisfied with the court, we should have profited by that; since that, he has passed into England; there he powerfully assisted in the restoration, there he gained a fortune, and, after all, he returned to the service of the king. Well, if he has returned to the service of the king, it is because he is well paid in that service.'

'We will pay him even better, that is all.'

'Oh! monsieur, excuse me; D'Artagnan has a high respect for his word, and where that is once engaged he keeps it.'

'What do you conclude, then?' said Fouquet, with great inquietude.

'At present, the principal thing is to parry a dangerous blow.'

'And how is it to be parried?'

'Listen.'

'But D'Artagnan will come and render an account to the king of his mission.'

'Oh, we have time enough to think about that.'

'How so? You are much in advance of him, I presume?'

'Nearly ten hours.'

'Well, in ten hours—'

Aramis shook his pale head. 'Look at these clouds which flit across the heavens; at these swallows which cut the air. D'Artagnan moves more quickly than the clouds or the birds; D'Artagnan is the wind which carries them.'

'A strange man!'

'I tell you, he is superhuman, monsieur. He is of my own age, and I have known him these five-and-thirty years.'

'Well?'

'Well, listen to my calculation, monsieur. I send M. du Vallon off to you two hours after midnight. M. du Vallon was eight hours in advance of me; when did M. du Vallon arrive?'

'About four hours ago.'

'You see, then, that I gained four upon him; and yet Porthos is a staunch horseman, and he has left on the road eight dead horses, whose bodies I came to successively. I rode post fifty leagues; but I have the gout, the

court. Day was dawning. The court was deserted; the fowls, even, had not left their roosts. Not a servant appeared. Every door was closed.

'Good! all is still,' said D'Artagnan to himself. 'Never mind: I am up first in the house. Let us dress; that will be so much done.' And D'Artagnan dressed himself. But, this time, he endeavoured not to give to the costume of M. Agnan that *bougeoise* and almost ecclesiastical rigidity he had affected before; he managed, by drawing his belt tighter, by buttoning his clothes in a different fashion, and by putting on his hat a little on one side, to restore to his person a little of that military character, the absence of which had surprised Aramis. This being done, he made free, or affected to make free with his host, and entered his chamber without ceremony. Aramis was asleep or feigned to be so. A large book lay open upon his night-desk, a wax-light was still burning in its silver sconce. This was more than enough to prove to D'Artagnan the quiescence of the prelate's night, and the good intentions of his waking. The musketeer did to the bishop precisely as the bishop had done to Porthos—he tapped him on the shoulder. Evidently Aramis pretended to sleep; for, instead of waking suddenly, he who slept so lightly required a repetition of the summons.

'Ah! ah! is that you?' said he, stretching his arms. 'What an agreeable surprise! *Ma foi!* Sleep had made me forget I had the happiness to possess you. What o'clock is it?'

'I do not know,' said D'Artagnan, a little embarrassed. 'Early, I believe. But, you know, that devil of a habit of waking with the day, sticks to me still.'

'Do you wish that we should go out so soon?' asked Aramis. 'It appears to me to be very early.'

'Just as you like.'

'I thought we had agreed not to get on horseback before eight.'

'Possibly; but I had so great a wish to see you, that I said to myself, the sooner the better.'

'And my seven hours' sleep!' said Aramis. 'Take care; I had reckoned upon them, and what I lose of them I must make up.'

'But it seems to me that, formerly, you were less of a sleeper than that, dear friend; your blood was alive, and you were never to be found in bed.'

half stupefied, let him do as he liked, and confounded himself in excuses. When he was ready, Aramis took him by the hand, and led him, making him place his foot with precaution on every step of the stairs, preventing him running against door-frames, turning him this way and that, as if Aramis had been the giant and Porthos the dwarf. Soul set fire to and animated matter. A horse was waiting, ready saddled, in the courtyard. Porthos mounted. Then Aramis himself took the horse by the bridle, and led him over some dung spread in the yard, with the evident intention of suppressing noise. He, at the same time, held tight the horse's nose, to prevent him neighing. When arrived at the outward gate, drawing Porthos towards him, who was going off without even asking him what for: 'Now, friend Porthos, now, without drawing bridle, till you get to Paris,' whispered he in his ears, 'eat on horseback, drink on horseback, but lose not a minute.'

'That's enough; I will not stop.'

'This letter to M. Fouquet, cost what it may, he must have it to-morrow before mid-day.'

'He shall.'

'And do not forget one thing, my friend.'

'What is that?'

'That you are riding out on a hunt for your *brevet* of duc and peer.'

'Oh! oh!' said Porthos, with his eyes sparkling; 'I will do it in twenty-four hours, in that case.'

'Try.'

'Then let go the bridle—and forward, Goliath!'

Aramis did let go, not the bridle, but the horse's nose. Porthos released his hand, clapped spurs to his horse, which set off at a gallop. As long as he could distinguish Porthos through the darkness, Aramis followed him with his eyes: when he was completely out of sight, he re-entered the yard. Nothing had stirred in D'Artagnan's apartment. The valet placed on watch at the door had neither seen any light, nor heard any noise. Aramis closed his door carefully, sent the lackey to bed, and quickly sought his own. D'Artagnan really suspected nothing, therefore thought he had gained everything, when he awoke in the morning, about half-past four. He ran to the window in his shirt. The window looked out upon the

gravel, and what else I know not; so that fatigue kills me. I was obliged to dismount at Tours, since that, rolling along in a carriage, half dead, sometimes overturned, drawn upon the sides, and sometimes on the back of the carriage, always with four spirited horses at full gallop, I have arrived—arrived, gaining four hours upon Porthos; but, see you, D'Artagnan does not weigh three hundred-weight, as Porthos does; D'Artagnan has not the gout and gravel, as I have; he is not a horseman, he is a centaur. D'Artagnan, look you, set out for Belle-Isle when I set out for Paris; and D'Artagnan, notwithstanding my ten hours' advance, D'Artagnan will arrive within two hours after me.'

'But, then, accidents?'

'He never meets with accidents.'

'Horses may fail him.'

'He will run as fast as a horse.'

'Good God! what a man!'

'Yes, he is a man whom I love and admire. I love him because he is good, great, and loyal; I admire him because he represents in my eyes the culminating point of human power; but, whilst loving and admiring him, I fear him, and am on my guard against him. Now then, I resume, monsieur; in two hours D'Artagnan will be here; be beforehand with him. Go to the Louvre, and see the king, before he sees D'Artagnan.'

'What shall I say to the king?'

'Nothing; give him Belle-Isle.'

'Oh! Monsieur d'Herblay! Monsieur d'Herblay,' cried Fouquet, 'what projects crushed all at once!'

'After one project that has failed, there is always another project that may lead to fortune; we should never despair. Go, monsieur, and go at once.'

'But that garrison, so carefully chosen, the king will change it directly.'

'That garrison, monsieur, was the king's when it entered Belle-Isle; it is yours now; it is the same with all garrisons after a fortnight's occupation. Let things go on, monsieur. Do you see any inconvenience in having an army at the end of a year, instead of two regiments? Do you not see that your garrison of to-day will make you partisans at La Rochelle, Nantes, Bordeaux, Toulouse—in short, wherever they may be sent to? Go to the

king, monsieur; go; time flies, and D'Arragnan, while we are losing time, is flying, like an arrow, along the high-road.'

'Monsieur d'Herblay, you know that each word from you is a germ which fructifies in my thoughts. I will go to the Louvre.'

'Instantly, will you not?'

'I only ask time to change my dress.'

'Remember that D'Arragnan has no need to pass through Saint-Mande; but will go straight to the Louvre; that is cutting off an hour from the advantage that yet remains to us.'

'D'Arragnan may have everything except my English horses. I shall be at the Louvre in twenty-five minutes.' And, without losing a second, Fouquet gave orders for his departure.

Aramis had only time to say to him, 'Return as quickly as you go; for I shall await you impatiently.'

Five minutes after, the superintendent was flying along the road to Paris. During this time, Aramis desired to be shown the chamber in which Porthos was sleeping. At the door of Fouquet's cabinet he was folded in the arms of Pélisson, who had just heard of his arrival, and had left his office to see him. Aramis received, with that friendly dignity which he knew so well how to assume, these caresses, respectful as earnest; but all at once stopping on the landing-place, 'What is that I hear up yonder?'

There was, in fact, a hoarse, growling kind of noise, like the roar of a hungry tiger, or an impatient lion. 'Oh, that is nothing,' said Pélisson, smiling.

'Well, but—'

'It is M. du Vallon snoring.'

'Ah! true,' said Aramis: 'I had forgotten. No one but he is capable of making such a noise. Allow me, Pélisson, to inquire if he wants anything.'

'And you will permit me to accompany you?'

'Oh, certainly?' and both entered the chamber. Porthos was stretched upon the bed; his face was violet rather than red; his eyes were swelled; his mouth was wide open. The roaring which escaped from the deep cavities of his chest made the glass of the windows vibrate. To those developed and clearly defined muscles starting from his face, to his hair matted with sweat, to the energetic heaving of his chin and shoulders, it was impossible to refuse a certain degree of admiration. Strength carried to this point is semi-

'You see I am doing my best,' said Porthos, putting on his *haut-de-chausses*.

'Very well.'

'This is something in haste?'

'It is more than that, it is serious, Porthos.'

'Oh, oh!'

'D'Arragnan has questioned you, has he not?'

'Questioned me?'

'Yes, at Belle-Isle?'

'Not the least in the world.'

'Are you sure of that, Porthos?'

'*Parbleu!*'

'It is impossible. Recollect yourself.' 'He asked me what I was doing, and I told him—studying topography. I would have made use of another word which you employed one day.'

'"Castrametation"?'

'Yes, that's it; but I never could recollect it.'

'All the better. What more did he ask you?'

'Who M. Getard was.'

'Next?'

'Who M. Jupinet was.'

'He did not happen to see our plan of fortifications, did he?'

'Yes.'

'The devil he did!'

'But don't be alarmed, I had rubbed out your writing with India-rubber. It was impossible for him to suppose you had given me any advice in those works.'

'Ay; but our friend has phenomenally keen eyes.'

'What are you afraid of?'

'I fear that everything is discovered, Porthos; the matter is, then, to prevent a great misfortune. I have given orders to my people to close all the gates and doors. D'Arragnan will not be able to get out before daybreak. Your horse is ready saddled; you will gain the first relay, by five o'clock in the morning you will have traversed fifteen leagues. Come!'

Aramis then assisted Porthos to dress, piece by piece, with as much celerity as the most skilful valet de chambre could have done. Porthos,